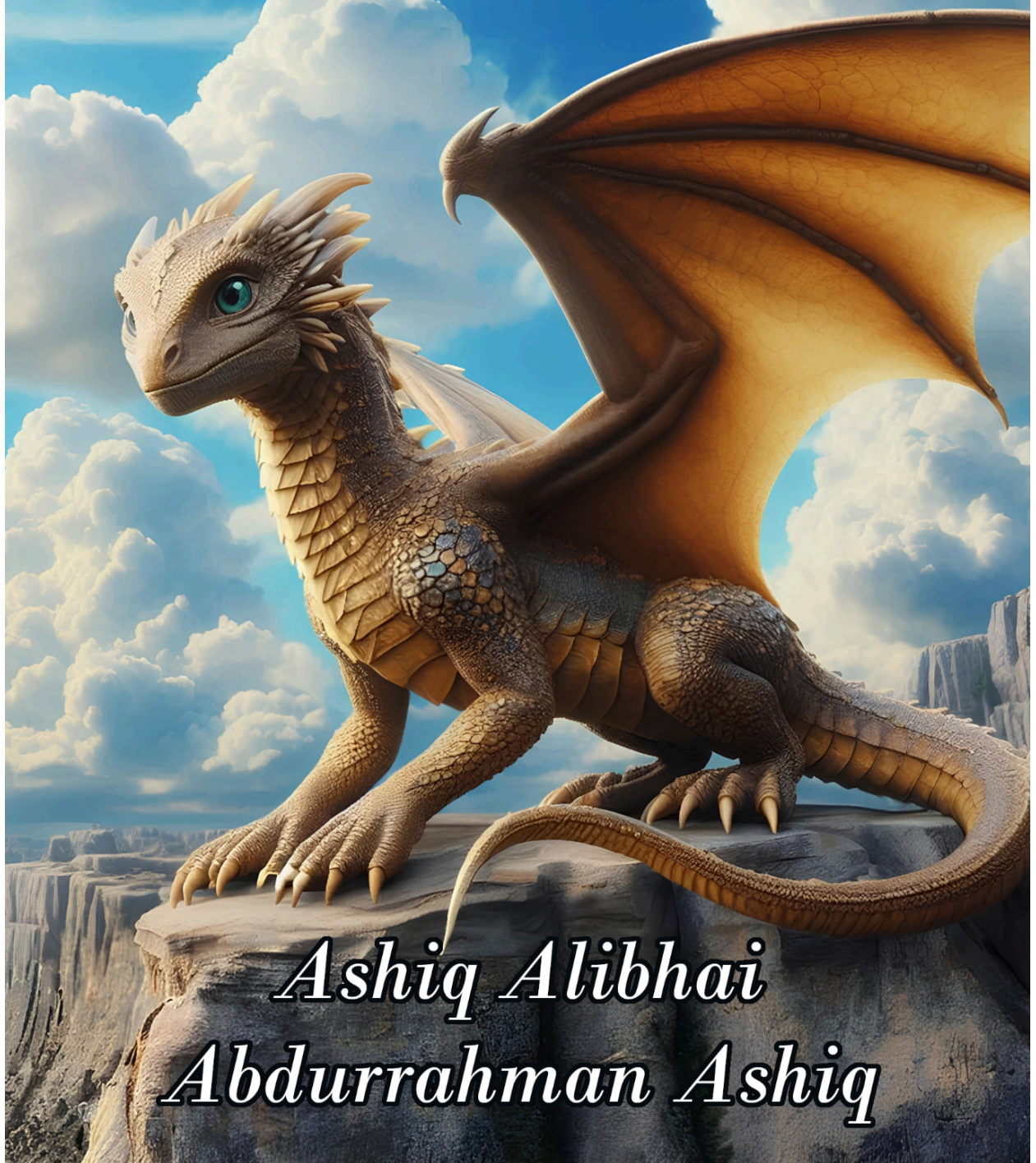


The Last Standing Dragon



*Ashiq Alibhai
Abdurrahman Ashiq*

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Prologue: Shadow of the Past

The wind howled through the blackened ruins, and carried the scent of ash and something colder—something final. Heavy storm clouds swirled overhead like smoke from a burning house as the rain came and went, leaving the blackened ground slick with mud but the destruction untouched.

She stood alone in the center of it all.

Her claws dug into the wet earth, her obsidian black scales dull beneath the dim light of the storm. She barely noticed the rainwater trickling down her snout as it mixed with the streaks of soot and dried blood that clung to her. The air was thick with silence, the kind that pressed down like a weight, the kind that only existed in places where no voices remained to break it.

They were all gone.

Her mother, whose voice once carried warmth even in anger, whose wings wrapped around her in the cold.

Her father, fierce and steady, his presence like the mountain itself—unshakable, unbreakable.

Her brother, her twin, the only one who truly understood her, who flew beside her every day since they had learned to fly, who had laughed at her terrible jokes and whispered secrets only for her ears.

Gone.

Distant fires crackled, the last of them devouring what remained of the great halls—the very place where they had once lived, ruled, and found safety.

She tried to save them.

She fought until her claws cracked, until her wings tore, until her breath came in ragged, burning gasps. She screamed for them, reached for them, but the storm and the smoke swallowed her voice, swallowed her whole.

And now, she was all that was left.

She had no name anymore. Not really.

Once, she had been a daughter, a sister, a queen.

Now, she was nothing but a shadow, a ghost of what once was.

Her tail flicked and sent droplets of water flying into the mud. Somewhere in the back of her mind, a voice whispered that she should leave this place. That there was nothing here for her now.

But she couldn't. Not yet.

Because beneath the charred remains of what had once been her home, beneath the shattered stones and broken wooden beams, something else remained. Something colder than the storm, heavier than the silence.

The truth.

She closed her eyes and let the memories wash over her.

It started with whispers.

Not the wind, not the rain, but something else. Whispers that slithered through the halls at night, coiled in the corners and slipped through the cracks.

Her father heard them first. She remembered the way he stood at the mouth of the cave one evening and stared at the sky as if searching for something just out of sight. When she asked what was wrong, he only shook his head.

"Something is coming," he said.

She hadn't believed him. Not at first.

Then the shadows changed.

At first, it was little things. The air in the great halls had felt heavier, the torches flickered when there was no wind. The echoes of their voices stretched too long, as if something unseen listened to them.

And then, the sickness came.

Her mother fell first. A deep, unnatural sleep, her breath shallow, her wings limp. Nothing could wake her. Not fire, not water, not even the healers who flew in from the distant mountains.

Then her father followed—not with sickness, but with fury. He flew out into the storm and roared his grief at the loss of his mate. He returned, and, within days, joined her in eternal silence.

Then her brother.

She had clung to him in those final hours, whispered to him, begged him to hold on. He smiled—weak, tired, fading.

"It's okay," he murmured. "The Creator's will is enough for us."

Then he was gone, and she was alone.

And that was when the last part of her shattered.

Now, standing in the ruins, she felt nothing.

No sorrow. No grief.

Only emptiness.

And then a voice.

Not her father's. Not her mother's. Not her brother's.

A voice like stone cracking, like ice shattering, like the wind in a graveyard.

"You have lost everything," it said.

She did not flinch. She did not turn.

"But you are not weak," the voice continued. Each word hung in the air like frost.

A shadow moved at the edge of her vision. Something vast, something ancient.

"I can give you power."

She bared her fangs, a growl rising in her throat. "Power?" she hissed.

"What use is power when everything I loved is gone?"

A low chuckle curled around her like smoke.

"Power is the only thing that remains when everything else is gone."

She stood there for a long time.

The storm raged on.

The ruins lay silent.

And deep within her chest, something cold and sharp took root.

When she finally spoke, her voice was quiet, but steady.

"Show me."

And the shadows obeyed.

Chapter 1: A Lazy Morning and a Growing Mystery

In the cool, damp shadows of the dragon family's cave, the air hummed with the sounds of a typical morning. The walls of the cavern, rough and ancient, glistened with tiny droplets of water that trickled down from the moss-covered ceiling. Sunlight filtered through a narrow crack in the rocky entrance, and cast a golden beam that danced across the floor. The youngest dragon, Bilal, sprawled on a bed of soft, emerald-green moss near the entrance. His golden scales shimmered faintly in the sunlight. Each scale, edged in faint orange, caught the light like a tiny mirror. A small flock of sparrows chirped and darted outside. Their tiny wings fluttered like leaves in the breeze, oblivious to the dragons lounging inside.

"I call dibs on the biggest trout in the stream today!" announced Aisha, Bilal's fiery red sister, as she stretched her wings wide and let out a long, rumbling yawn. Her scales glowed like molten lava, and her amber eyes sparkled with mischief. She flicked her tail, sending a few stray sparks flying into the air.

"You called dibs yesterday," replied her twin, Ali, a dark gray dragon with a habit of chewing twigs. His scales were the color of storm clouds, and his piercing silver eyes narrowed as he spoke. A half-chewed twig dangled from the corner of his mouth. "And you didn't even finish your fish."

"That's because you told the 'joke' about the fish that walked into a cave," Aisha said, rolling her eyes so dramatically that her entire head tilted with the motion. "It was so bad, the trout practically jumped out of the stream to get away from you."

Bilal chuckled, his deep, rumbling laugh echoing softly through the cave. He sat up, his golden claws digging into the moss as he stretched. "It wasn't even that bad," he teased, "although the trout might disagree. I think it swam off just to avoid hearing the punchline again."

Before the siblings could get into a full-blown debate, the sound of laughter echoed from deeper in the cave. The laughter grew louder, accompanied by the rhythmic thud of claws against stone. Bilal's three best friends padded in, each carrying something they'd picked up on their morning romp.

Hassan, a small silver dragon with scales that shimmered like starlight, dropped a smooth, shiny stone at Bilal's feet. The stone was perfectly oval, its surface polished by centuries of flowing water.

"Check it out!" Hassan said, his voice brimming with excitement. His bright blue eyes sparkled as he nudged the stone with his claw. "Looks like a dragon egg, doesn't it?"

Bilal tilted his head, studying the stone with a critical eye. "It's a rock," he said finally, though a smile tugged at the corners of his mouth.

"An egg-shaped rock," Hassan corrected with a grin. His tail swished back and forth like an excited puppy's.

Rumaan, the green dragon with slightly oversized wings, who loved pomegranates, flopped down beside them. Her scales glittered, the color of fresh spring leaves. She balanced a long, crooked stick on her nose, her tongue sticking out in concentration. "I'm practicing for when we have to cross a rickety bridge or something on our epic adventures," she said, her voice muffled as she tried not to move her mouth too much.

"You can barely balance," muttered Zaid, the tallest of the group, a sandy-colored dragon with a knack for finding snacks. His scales were the color of sunbaked earth, and his amber eyes gleamed with quiet amusement. He held up a bunch of plump, purple berries in one claw, their sweet scent filling the air. "Anyone hungry?"

"Always," Bilal said, grabbing a handful of berries and popping them into his mouth. The burst of sweetness made his tail twitch with delight.

As they settled in, the cave felt alive with warmth and chatter. The sound of their voices mingled with the soft drip of water and the distant chirping of

birds outside. Bilal couldn't help but smile. Days like this felt so perfect—his siblings teasing each other, his friends being their silly selves, and the whole world waiting outside their little hideaway. The cave was their sanctuary, a place where they could be themselves without a care in the world.

But Bilal couldn't shake a tiny thought that had been nagging at the back of his mind for days. Their mom had been gone longer than usual. She often flew off to other parts of the valley, to help dragons with disputes or to share her wisdom. But this time, she hadn't left a message about where she was going or when she would return. Bilal's chest tightened as he glanced at the empty spot near the back of the cave where she usually slept. Her absence felt like a quiet shadow, one that no one else seemed to notice.

"So what's the plan today?" asked Aisha, snapping Bilal out of his thoughts. She was perched on a rock, her wings folded neatly at her sides, her fiery scales casting a warm glow on the cave walls.

"Probably stick balancing and fish jokes," Ali joked, his voice dripping with sarcasm. He flicked the half-chewed twig at Aisha, who dodged it with a snort.

Bilal laughed, pushing the worry aside. "Or maybe we can think of a new game. Something... different."

"Different like what?" asked Hassan, his eyes brightening with curiosity. He leaned forward, his silver scales catching the light.

Bilal grinned, his tail wagging. "Let's make it up as we go. We're dragons, aren't we? It's what we do."

And with that, the group tumbled out of the cave, laughing and nudging each other playfully, ready for another day of adventure. The sunlight washed over them as they emerged, the world outside a vibrant tapestry of green forests, sparkling streams, and distant mountains. The air was fresh and crisp, filled with the scent of pine and wildflowers.

But in the distance, unseen by the happy group, a shadow passed over the land. It was faint, like a wisp of smoke, but it moved with purpose. Far away, on a lonely island surrounded by churning, ink-black waters, something stirred. Deep within the island's heart, a pair of glowing eyes opened, and a low, rumbling growl echoed through the darkness. Something ancient and powerful was awakening—something that would change their lives forever.

The preceding was an excerpt of the Last Standing Dragon. You can purchase the full book, from various vendors, here:

<https://ashiqalibhai.com/books/the-last-standing-dragon.html>